The First Intermediate Period

The first key event that occurred during the First Intermediate Period (2,181 – 2,040 BCE) was the complete disintegration of the government. This led to the country dividing itself into several separate states that were independent from each other. As a result, two key centers emerged: Heirokonpolis and Thebes. New dynasties were established at both locations that ruled a divided Upper and Lower Egypt. These dynasties continued to fight each other until 2,055 BCE when Mentuhotep II finally reunited Egypt under the Theban rule.

Under the Theban king, Egypt began the Middle Kingdom Period (2,040 – 1,782 BCE) that is also referred to the Classical Era. Egypt's economy stabilized and the arts flourished as Thebes grew prosperous. The Egyptian kings pushed down into Nubia, ruled over the southern lands and constructed forts to protect their trading posts. It was also at this time that the River Nile flooded inland so much so that many suffered from famine. There was a sudden decline in Thebes' power and Hyksos was able to gain influence in Egypt.

Not much is known about the enigmatic Hyksos people but it is believed they originated from modern day Syria around 1,800 BCE. The names of these foreign rulers are Semitic originally but scholars are still unable to determine what ethnic group they belonged to. The Hyksos people gained power gradually and had seized Lower Egypt by 1720 BCE. Upper Egypt ultimately became their vassal, the king a mere puppet instead of an actual ruler. This point in time is referred to as the Second Intermediate Period (1,782 – 1,570 BCE), when the foreign Hyksos rulers controlled the region. Despite the hatred towards them, the Hyksos brought with them new technologies and weapons, such as the chariot and the composite bow.

By 1,700 BCE, the domain of Kush had become powerful in its own right and allied itself with Hyksos against the Theban kingdom. The native Egyptians initiated numerous military campaigns to force the Hyksos from the country and overthrow Nubia, yet all of them proved to be unsuccessful. This continued until the arrival of Ahmose I from Thebes who showed